DEBATE

MODULE 1

DISCOVERING DEBATE

Learning Goals

- Explain what a debate is.
- Understand the difference between a debate and a discussion.
- Understand what a motion/topic is.
- Identify the For and Against sides.
- Understand the basic roles of debaters.
- Use basic debate vocabulary in sentences.
- Follow simple debate rules.
- Express disagreement respectfully.
- Give a simple argument on a familiar topic.

Prepared by Rahim Shaikh
Co-founder, Curriculum Director, Excellence

1. What Is a Debate?

A debate is a structured exchange of ideas in which two sides present different views on a particular topic.

One side supports the topic, while the other side opposes it.

Example: “Students should be allowed to use mobile phones in school.”

- For: “Students should be allowed to use mobile phones because they can be useful for learning.”
- Against: “Students should not be allowed to use mobile phones because they can distract students from their studies.”

Both sides have an opportunity to present arguments, respond to the other side, and defend their position.

> Remember: A debate is not about shouting or proving that someone is wrong. It is about presenting ideas clearly, logically, and respectfully.

Think About It

If two students have different opinions about a topic, does that automatically mean they are having a debate?

Not necessarily. A debate usually follows a structure and gives each side an opportunity to present and defend its position.

2. Debate vs. Discussion

DEBATE	DISCUSSION
Usually has two opposing sides	People may share different ideas
Has a specific topic or motion	Can be more open-ended
Speakers support or oppose a position	People exchange ideas
Arguments and rebuttals are important	Sharing thoughts is the main focus
Usually follows a structure	Can be more informal

Example

Discussion: “Let's talk about social media.”

Debate: “Social media does more harm than good.”

The second statement gives us something that can be supported or challenged.

> Remember: A discussion is mainly about exchanging ideas. A debate is about presenting and defending a particular position.

3. What Is a Motion?

A motion is the statement or proposition that the debaters discuss. Think of it as the main idea or statement of the debate.

Examples of Motions

- School uniforms should be compulsory.
- Homework should be banned.
- Every student should learn a sport.
- Online classes are better than classroom learning.
- Books are better than movies.
- Students should be allowed to use mobile phones in school.

A good motion gives students something to agree or disagree with.

Try It!

Which of these can be used as a debate motion?

A. “My favourite sport is cricket.”
B. “Students should have a four-day school week.”
C. “What is your favourite food?”

> Answer: B. “Students should have a four-day school week.” It can be supported or opposed, so it can be used as a debate motion.

4. For and Against

FOR

The For side supports the motion. You may also hear: Proposition, Supporting side, Affirmative.

Example: “Homework should be banned because students need more time to rest and take part in other activities.”

AGAINST

The Against side disagrees with the motion. You may also hear: Opposition, Opposing side, Negative.

Example: “Homework should not be banned because regular practice can improve students' learning.”

> Remember: FOR = Support the motion | AGAINST = Oppose the motion.

5. Basic Debate Structure

1. Introduction — The speaker introduces the topic and clearly states their position.

Sample Introduction — For

> “Good morning, everyone. Today, we are going to debate the topic, ‘Students should be allowed to use mobile phones in school.’ I am speaking in favour of this motion. I believe that mobile phones can be useful for learning, communication, and accessing educational resources. I would like to present my points in support of this motion.”

Sample Introduction — Against

> “Good morning, everyone. Today, we are going to debate the topic, ‘Students should be allowed to use mobile phones in school.’ I am speaking against this motion. I believe that mobile phones can distract students and affect their concentration in the classroom. I would like to explain why I oppose this motion.”

2. Arguments — The speaker gives reasons to support their position.

Example: “My first argument is that mobile phones can provide students with quick access to educational information.”

3. Rebuttal — The speaker responds to an argument made by the other side.

Example: “The opposition says that mobile phones are useful for learning. However, they can also become a major distraction during lessons.”

4. Conclusion — The speaker summarises their main points and finishes their speech.

Example: “To conclude, mobile phones may have some benefits, but their disadvantages in the classroom cannot be ignored. Therefore, I oppose the motion.”

> Easy Formula: Introduce → Argue → Respond → Conclude
>
> Remember: I say it → I explain it → I defend it → I conclude it.

6. Who Does What?

First Speaker

- Introduces the topic.
- States the team's position.
- Gives the first arguments.

Example: “Good morning, everyone. We are speaking in favour of the motion. Our first point is that...”

Second Speaker

- Adds more arguments.
- Gives examples or evidence.
- Responds to the other side.

Example: “Building on my teammate's point, I would like to explain why...”

Third Speaker

- Gives further arguments.
- Focuses more on rebuttal.
- Strengthens the team's position.

Example: “The opposition has argued that..., but this overlooks an important point...”

Final Speaker

- Summarises the team's strongest points.
- Responds to important arguments.
- Gives a strong conclusion.

Example: “To conclude, our team has shown that...”

> Beginner Tip: For students debating for the first time, start with two speakers per side. As students become more confident, introduce larger teams and more roles.

7. Basic Debate Vocabulary

WORD	MEANING	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
Motion	The topic being debated	“The motion for today's debate is ‘Homework should be banned.’”
Position	The side you support	“My position is that school uniforms should be compulsory.”
Argument	A reason supporting your position	“My first argument is that uniforms create equality among students.”
Evidence	Information that supports an argument	“We need evidence to support our argument.”
Example	Something that helps explain an argument	“Let me give you an example to explain my point.”
Opposition	The side that disagrees with you	“The opposition believes that homework is necessary.”
Rebuttal	A response to the other side's argument	“My rebuttal to the opposition's argument is that students also need time to rest.”
Counterargument	An argument against another argument	“Our counterargument is that technology can also be used for educational purposes.”
Point	An idea or argument you present	“I would like to make one important point.”
Conclusion	The final part of your speech	“In conclusion, I strongly support this motion.”
Speaker	A person presenting an argument	“The first speaker will introduce the motion.”
Audience	People listening to the debate	“We should speak clearly so that the audience can understand us.”

Use It in a Debate

- “The motion for today's debate is _____.”
- “My position is _____.”
- “My first argument is _____.”
- “Let me give you an example.”
- “The opposition says _____.”
- “My rebuttal is _____.”
- “I would like to make one important point.”
- “In conclusion, I believe _____.”

8. Rules of a Good Debate

Rule 1: Respect the Speaker

Listen when someone else is speaking. Do not interrupt. Wait for your turn.

Rule 2: Attack the Argument, Not the Person

Instead of “You don't know anything,” say “I disagree with that argument because…”

Rule 3: Give Reasons

Don't simply say “I disagree.” Say “I disagree because…” A good debater explains why.

Rule 4: Listen Carefully

You need to understand the other side before you can respond to it. Good debaters are good listeners.

Rule 5: Stay on the Topic

Your arguments should relate to the motion.

Rule 6: Be Confident, but Respectful

A strong debater does not need to shout. Speak clearly, maintain eye contact, and use an appropriate tone.

Rule 7: Use Appropriate Language

Avoid insults, personal comments, offensive language, and mocking the other speaker. Use respectful expressions such as “I respectfully disagree.”

9. First Debate Challenge

Motion: “Every student should learn to speak English.”

Step 1 — Choose your side: FOR or AGAINST

Step 2 — State your position: “I am in favour of this motion.” / “I am against this motion.”

Step 3 — Give one reason: “I believe this because…”

Step 4 — Give one example: “For example…”

Step 5 — Speak: Speak for 30–45 seconds.

Sample Response

> “Good morning, everyone. I am in favour of the motion that every student should learn to speak English. I believe English is useful for communication and education. For example, students may need English when they communicate with people from different parts of the country or the world. Therefore, I believe that learning spoken English can be beneficial for students.”

Module 1 Key Takeaway

A good debater listens carefully, thinks clearly, speaks confidently, gives reasons, and respects different opinions.

A debate is not a fight.
A debate is a structured exchange of ideas.

Think clearly. Speak confidently. Support your ideas. Respect the other side.